Free Will, Pain, and Suffering

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> *"Pain insists upon being attended to. God whispers to us in our pleasures, speaks in our consciences, but shouts in our pains. It is his megaphone to rouse a deaf world."*
>
> — C.S. Lewis, *The Problem of Pain*

Suffering will be a major topic in your counseling career, so I want to share my understanding of pain and suffering with you. I am not a theologian, but I have read extensively on this topic, and I have written a chapter on suffering in one of my books. If you have not yet given this topic careful thought, you may want to read C.S. Lewis's *The Problem of Pain* and Dr. James Dobson's *When God Doesn't Make Sense*.

Discussion

To begin with, God created a perfect world and lived in harmony with man. There was no sin, no illness, and no genetic deformity. However, He gave Adam and Eve free will, and they used that free will to rebel against God. From that point on, sin entered the world, and with it came physical problems, genetic deformities, and much more. God did not cause these problems; man did, through his free-will rebellion.

Free will is an important factor to consider as we think about pain and suffering. It is also important to consider determinism. Some scientists and philosophers argue that everything is determined and that free will is simply an illusion.

As a counselor, when you consider the "problem" of pain and suffering, it is important to keep the following factors in mind.

1. Pain and suffering may be caused by others.

If your client comes to you with pain or suffering, whether physical or mental, remember that the condition may have been caused by *others* and may have little or nothing to do with anything your client did. For example, if a drunk driver lost control and plowed into your client's car, the pain and suffering did not result from anything *your client did*. Similarly, if your client suffers from depression or anxiety caused by childhood sexual abuse, your client had little or nothing to do with causing that condition.

2. Accidents happen.

In my opinion, God does not control everything that happens in life, although He is certainly aware of everything and can intervene in this world whenever He chooses. When God intervenes, we call it an "answer to prayer" or a "miracle."

I also do not believe that God orchestrates or *causes* accidents or harmful events to punish people or to make them "grow" through pain. Remember, when God first created Adam and Eve, there was no pain or suffering, and they lived in harmony with Him. If God had not given us free will, we would presumably still be living in perfect peace and harmony with Him, without pain or suffering.

As we know, man did fall by disobeying God, and at that instant sin entered the world. God is not the cause of pain and suffering; man is. When a drunk driver loses control and plows head-on into another car, I do not believe that God *caused* it to happen for some noble purpose. Deliberately causing the death of a young child in that car would run contrary to everything we know about an all-loving God. In my opinion, that pain and suffering are the result of man's free will and sin.

3. Does everything happen for a purpose?

Some of you probably assume that "everything happens for a purpose." This statement assumes that God is the agent of everything that happens, that He controls every event in this world. However, that runs contrary to the fact that He gave us free will to follow Him or to disobey Him. If God controlled *everything*, including every action of man, the world would be without sin, and there would be no pain or suffering. With that in mind, let's look at the attributes of God.

4. God is omnipotent.

This means that God is all-powerful. He has the *power* to do anything He wants. However, this does not mean that He uses His power to *control everything* that happens in this world. If He did, I doubt there would be any pain and suffering. God has given us free will, which means He does not always exert His omnipotence. He holds back His power to allow us free will.

5. God is omniscient.

God's omniscience means that He is *aware of* everything that happens. However, being aware of our actions does not mean that He *controls* everything, such as our thoughts or our actions. If God controlled every thought and action, no one would ever sin.

6. God is omnipresent.

This means that God is everywhere, present in every place at the same time. However, being present everywhere does not mean that God *controls* or *causes* everything. The fact that God is omnipresent does not mean that He causes pain or suffering.

7. The influence of Satan.

If God is not the *cause* of pain and suffering, *who* or *what* is? We have already seen that human beings are often the cause, because God gave us free will. That free will allows us to turn toward Him or away from Him, to live a righteous life or a life of sin.

However, as Christians we believe there is another source of pain and suffering: Satan. Remember the story of Job? God allowed Satan to test Job and to cause him horrendous pain and suffering. Why God allows Satan to have power in this world is a very big question, but He does, and people have suffered as a result of Satan's influence.

8. Once again, accidents happen.

In addition to man's free will and Satan's influence, I believe that accidents sometimes simply happen, without any hidden motive or purpose on the part of God, man, or Satan. This brings us face to face with the question of determinism.

Some people believe that God determines and controls everything that happens in this world. I do not. Just because God is omnipotent, omniscient, and omnipresent does not mean that He causes or controls every event in our world. I believe that accidents happen and that they are part of living in a fallen world.

If I sneeze and wreck the car, I do not immediately turn to God and try to figure out what purpose He had in making me wreck it. If my child were to die of Sudden Infant Death Syndrome, I would not ask God why He *caused* it or what He wanted me to learn from it.

Instead, I would remember that we live in a fallen and broken world. We are not in the Garden of Eden anymore. We live in a world with genetic problems, cancer, brain damage, miscarriage, and much more, and God did not *cause* these diseases and disorders so that we could "learn" or "grow" from them.

In my opinion, God did not cause an incredible man named Nick Vujicic to be born without arms and legs so that He could use Nick for His purposes. God *allowed* Nick to be born this way, and He gave Nick the free will to turn to Him or away from Him. Nick made a free-will choice to turn to God, and that has made all the difference in his life and in the lives of countless others. His story is well worth hearing.



Watch Nick's story

"Inspiring man born without arms or legs – Nick Vujicic," *60 Minutes Australia*, on YouTube. Click the picture, or go to youtube.com/watch?v=tJnJ_fTYofQ

9. God's intentional will and our "little" wills.

It is clear from the Bible that God created us and has a plan for our lives, and that His plans for us are always *good*.

> *"For I know the plans I have for you," declares the LORD, "plans to prosper you and not to harm you, plans to give you hope and a future."*
>
> Jeremiah 29:11 (NIV)

However, despite God's intentional will for our lives, our free-will choices often interfere with His plans for us. But have no fear: God's intentional will for this world will ultimately win out, despite the little curves and detours we cause along the way. That intentional will is our redemption and salvation through Christ. Because of our sinful nature and the free will God gave us, not everyone will be saved. Yet God's intentional will is clear: He "wants all people to be saved and to come to a knowledge of the truth" (1 Timothy 2:4, NIV).

10. Turn to God.

Although I do not believe that God causes pain or suffering, He is always there for us to turn to when pain and suffering enter our lives. When we turn to God, we can often grow stronger and deeper in our faith and reap untold benefits, including our very salvation. As counselors, you will not always know *why* pain and suffering entered your clients' lives, but you can always encourage your clients to turn to God, the Creator of all things, for comfort and encouragement. God is love, and we can encourage our clients to look up and find their peace and rest in Him.

11. But why? Why?

Very often, I acknowledge to my clients that I really don't know *why* God allows pain and suffering, or the accidental or intentional death of infants. The answer to the *why* question is too big for my little "pea brain." God's ways are not our ways, and His thoughts are not our thoughts (Isaiah 55:8). Instead of asking *why*, I encourage clients to move on with their lives and ask, "What would You have me do now, Lord?" Perhaps you can encourage them to use their tragic circumstances for good.

12. The backdrop of heaven and eternity.

Although I don't always know *why* God allows bad things to happen, I encourage my Christian clients to view their pain and suffering against the backdrop of heaven and eternity. Our lives here are very short compared to eternity. Soon, very soon, we are going to see our Lord. We're not home yet. In the blink of an eye we will be with Christ and see Him face to face, and we will be reunited with our loved ones in heaven, where there is no pain or suffering. For Christians, "This is as bad as it gets." For non-Christians, "This is as good as it gets."

Bottom line: Help your clients live with an awareness of how brief this life on earth is compared to eternity, and with the knowledge that we will soon live forever in heaven with our Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ.

A Personal Note: Nick's Story

I want to tell you a little story about Nick. He is an evangelist, and one Sunday he came to my church to preach. His story was so inspiring that it literally changed my life.

First, I want to tell you something about myself. I have a very painful condition called peripheral neuropathy. I live with chronic pain, and I often have to take pain medication. That Sunday morning, before Nick preached, I woke up and started down the steps from my bedroom to the first floor. As usual, my feet hurt badly. I try not to, but I often feel sorry for myself, and I get depressed when I think about living the rest of my life with this pain.

Then I went to church and heard Nick preach. As he told his story, I began to feel immature and almost guilty as I heard how he had coped with his far greater challenges. His story immediately put my situation in perspective. In a flash, I realized how blessed my life has been, and the problem with my feet seemed almost trivial. I couldn't help thinking how much Nick would love to have my feet, just for a day, to walk down the steps instead of being carried. Of course, I was in tears as he told how he had turned to God.

As you may know, Nick has a wonderful sense of humor. One story he told was that he always keeps a pair of shoes in his closet, *just in case God grants him a miracle*.

Another Way to See It: Childbirth

As the father of three children, I know a little bit about childbirth. One way to think about the pain and suffering in this world is to consider the whole process of childbirth.

To begin with, we are conceived in our mother's womb, and we grow and develop for the next forty weeks. That time can be uncomfortable for the mother as well as the baby, but forty weeks is extremely short compared to the seventy or eighty years that lie ahead for the child. When the time comes to give birth, the mother typically goes through a great deal of pain. The baby has a difficult time too, being squeezed through a narrow opening. But the moment the baby is born and the mother holds her child in her arms, she begins to forget the pain of pregnancy and delivery. Before long, she hardly gives it a thought. Her eyes are on her new baby, and nothing will ever be the same again.

Now think of our own lives. Our time on this planet is extremely short compared to eternity in heaven. When we are "born" into heaven and leave this brief earthly life, we probably won't even remember the pain and suffering we went through in this world.

> *"...because the former troubles are forgotten and are hidden from my eyes."* Isaiah 65:16 (ESV)
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> *"For behold, I create new heavens and a new earth, and the former things shall not be remembered or come into mind."* Isaiah 65:17 (ESV)
>
> *"He will wipe every tear from their eyes. There will be no more death or mourning or crying or pain, for the old order of things has passed away."* Revelation 21:4 (NIV)

If we do remember anything, we probably won't pay much attention to it, because we will be in the presence of the Lord. Like pregnancy and childbirth, the pain and suffering of these fleeting moments in this world will be completely swallowed up by the joy and love we will know for eternity with our heavenly Father.

Keep things in perspective!

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